

HOUSE No. 3988

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Kip A. Diggs

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act relative to establishing the Barnstable home center for housing resources.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	DATE ADDED:
<i>Kip A. Diggs</i>	<i>2nd Barnstable</i>	<i>1/16/2025</i>
<i>Thomas W. Moakley</i>	<i>Barnstable, Dukes and Nantucket</i>	<i>4/10/2025</i>

HOUSE No. 3988

By Representative Diggs of Barnstable, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 3988) of Kip A. Diggs for legislation to establish the Barnstable home center for housing resources. Housing.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to establishing the Barnstable home center for housing resources.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. Chapter 23B of the General Laws is hereby amended by adding the
2 following section:-

3 Section 37. (a) For the purposes of section, the following words shall, unless the context
4 clearly requires otherwise, have the following meanings:

5 “Center”, the Barnstable Home Center.

6 “Executive office”, the executive office of housing and livable communities.

7 “Safe senior home program”, a program offering grants of up to \$5,000 for eligible
8 homeowners aged 60 and older earning less than 80 per cent of area median income to replace
9 aging heating systems. Additional costs can be covered through 0 per cent interest deferred
10 loans.

“Senior loan repair program”, a program to provide 0 per cent interest deferred payment home repair loans for seniors aged 62 and older earning less than 80 per cent of the area median income. Eligible repairs shall include minor fixes and critical safety upgrades, with loan amounts based on health and safety necessity.

(b) There shall be established within the executive office the Barnstable Home Center, which shall provide financial resources, training and counseling services to support housing stability and access for residents of the city known as the town of Barnstable.

(c) The center’s services shall include:

(i) financial resources for homebuyers and homeowners, including: (A) grants and low-interest loans for first-time homebuyers, including income-eligible seniors seeking to downsize or relocate to accessible housing; (B) emergency repair grants for income-eligible homeowners to address urgent safety and health hazards; and (C) financial support for qualified first-time homebuyers through the city known as the town of Barnstable homes initiative to ensure homes are affordable and meet specific income guidelines;

(ii) housing counseling, including: (A) pre-purchase counseling for first-time homebuyers to navigate the process of securing mortgages and finding affordable homes; (B) foreclosure prevention counseling to support homeowners at risk of losing their properties; (C) guidance for seniors to access affordable and accessible housing options, including age-restricted and assisted-living facilities; and (D) ongoing support for homebuyers in deed-restricted properties with owner-occupancy requirements and resale restrictions;

(iii) partnerships with developers and nonprofits, including: (A) collaborating with developers to create and expand housing options for income-eligible residents, including homes

designed for seniors and individuals with disabilities; (B) providing subsidies to developers building homes on town-owned land to ensure affordability within income limits set by the city know as the town of Barnstable homes initiative; and (C) working with local nonprofits to deliver community-based housing education and support services;

(iv) senior housing and safety programs, including: (A) establishing a senior loan repair program; and (B) creating a safe senior home program.; and

(v) a public awareness campaign, including conducting outreach to ensure residents are aware of available housing resource programs with materials tailored for seniors and first-time homebuyers.

(d) The center shall maintain a transparent application and reporting process for all grants and loans issued.

(e) The center shall, in consultation with the executive office, promulgate rules and regulations to implement and develop operational guidelines for the center and this section.

(f) The executive office shall prepare an annual report on the center that shall include: (i) the number of residents served by the center and each program category; (ii) the amount of financial resources distributed and its impact on housing stability in the city known as the town of Barnstable; and (iii) any recommendations for improving the delivery and effectiveness of services by the center. The annual report shall be submitted, not later than December 31, to the chairs of the joint committee on housing and the clerks of the house of representatives and senate.

SECTION 2. Chapter 29 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting, after
Section 2JJJJJ, the following section:-

Section 2KKKKKK. (a) There shall be established and set up on the books of the
commonwealth a separate fund, to be known as the Barnstable Home Resource Fund. It shall
consist of amounts credited to the fund in accordance with this section. The secretary of the
executive office of housing and livable communities shall be the custodian of the fund.

(b) The fund shall consist of: (i) revenue from appropriations or other money authorized
by the general court and specifically designated to be credited to the fund; (ii) interest earned on
money in the fund; and (iii) federal grants and other gifts, grants and donations. Amounts
credited to the fund shall not be subject to further appropriation and any money remaining in the
fund at the end of a fiscal year shall not revert to the General Fund.

(c) Money in the fund shall be expended to carry out the goals of the Barnstable home
center established in section 37 of chapter 23B to provide financial resources, training and
counseling services to support housing stability and access for residents of the city known as the
town of Barnstable, including (i) issuing grants and loans; (ii) establishing a senior loan repair
program; and (iii) creating a safe senior home program.

(d) The city known as the town of Barnstable shall annually, not later than December 31
of each year, report on the activity of the fund to the executive office of housing and livable
communities.

SECTION 3. This act shall take effect 180 days after passage.